

Power BI Licensing Overview

Power BI offers different licensing models to accommodate individual users, small businesses, and large organizations. Understanding the types of Power BI licenses is essential for selecting the right subscription plan based on the scale of data usage, collaboration needs, and budget.

Types of Power BI Licensing

There are three primary types of Power BI licenses:

1. Power BI Free (Individual Use)

Power BI Free is intended for individual users who want to explore data visualization capabilities without sharing reports or collaborating with others.

Key Features:

- Access to Power BI Desktop
- Ability to create and publish reports to Power BI Service
- Limited to personal workspace only
- No sharing, collaboration, or app workspace access

Best For:

Personal use, learning, and development purposes.

2. Power BI Pro

Power BI Pro is a user-based paid license that enables full collaboration and sharing capabilities within the Power BI ecosystem.

Key Features:

- All capabilities of Power BI Free
- Share dashboards and reports with other Pro users
- Create and manage workspaces
- Peer-to-peer sharing and app publishing
- Data refresh up to 8 times per day
- Export to PowerPoint and embed APIs
- Integration with Microsoft 365 tools

Best For:

Business users and teams who need to collaborate on reports and dashboards.

3. Power BI Premium

Power BI Premium offers advanced features, higher performance, and capacity-based licensing. It is designed for enterprise-level solutions.

There are two modes of Premium licensing:

- **Per User (Premium per user - PPU)**
- **Per Capacity (Premium Capacity - P1, P2, P3 tiers)**

Key Features (Premium Per User and Capacity):

- All Power BI Pro capabilities
- Access to advanced AI features (AutoML, Cognitive Services)
- Paginated Reports and deployment pipelines
- Larger dataset sizes (100 GB+)
- Data refresh up to 48 times per day
- On-premises report server (Power BI Report Server)
- Incremental data refresh
- Enhanced performance and scalability
- Multi-Geo deployment
- Dedicated capacity (only for Premium Capacity)

Best For:

Enterprises needing dedicated resources, large-scale deployment, enhanced data modeling, and advanced analytics.

Differences Between All Power BI License Types

Feature	Power BI Free	Power BI Pro	Power BI Premium Per User	Power BI Premium Per Capacity
Report Creation	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Share Reports and Dashboards	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
App Workspaces	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Collaboration	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Export to PPT, PDF	No	Yes	Yes	Yes

Feature	Power BI Free	Power BI Pro	Power BI Premium Per User	Power BI Premium Per Capacity
Data Refresh Frequency	Manual	8/day	48/day	48/day
AI and Machine Learning	No	No	Yes	Yes
Paginated Reports	No	No	Yes	Yes
Dataset Size Limit	1 GB	1 GB	100 GB	400 GB
Storage Limit	10 GB/user	10 GB/user	100 TB (shared capacity)	100 TB (dedicated)
Power BI Report Server	No	No	No	Yes
Price	Free	\$10/user/month	\$20/user/month	Starts from \$4,995/month

Benefits of Power BI Premium Over Power BI Pro

Power BI Premium offers several advantages over Power BI Pro, especially for organizations that require robust, scalable, and enterprise-grade BI solutions.

1. Scalability and Performance

- Premium provides dedicated cloud compute and storage resources, ensuring better performance for large-scale dashboards and datasets.

2. Advanced Data Handling

- Supports large datasets (up to 400 GB) and enables features like incremental refresh and XMLA endpoints for enterprise-grade modeling.

3. AI and Machine Learning Integration

- Access to AutoML, Azure Cognitive Services, and advanced natural language processing for enhanced insights.

4. Paginated Reports

- Create pixel-perfect, paginated reports similar to SSRS for operational reporting needs.

5. On-Premises Reporting

- Premium Capacity includes Power BI Report Server, allowing users to publish and view reports within their local infrastructure.

6. Greater Data Refresh Frequency

- Up to 48 scheduled refreshes per day versus 8 in Power BI Pro, ideal for near real-time reporting.

7. Enterprise Deployment Features

- Premium includes deployment pipelines for managing report lifecycle stages (Dev, Test, Prod), and supports multi-geo capabilities for data residency compliance.

8. Unlimited Distribution

- Reports and dashboards created using Premium Capacity can be shared with free users within the organization (Pro required only for authoring).